

A Ticket for Tomorrow

Book 8 of 10

*She bought a ticket to a city she had never visited.
She almost did not go.*

CEFR Level A1 | Adult Graded Reader

Setting: A small English town; then Manchester for one weekend.

Genre: Personal Growth / Hopeful Fiction

Characters

- Rosa - 31. Nurse. Careful, kind, used to putting others first.
- Paula - 34. Rosa's colleague and friend. Warm and direct.
- Marcus - 36. A chef in Manchester. Meets Rosa on her first evening.

A Ticket for Tomorrow

Rosa buys the ticket on a Tuesday evening after a long shift. She is tired. Her feet hurt. She is in the kitchen in her nurse's uniform. She opens her laptop, goes to the train website, and types: Manchester. She has never been to Manchester. She buys a return ticket - Saturday to Sunday. She closes the laptop. She does not tell anyone.

Rosa lives in a small town. She grew up there. She works at the local hospital. She has a comfortable, tidy flat near the park. She has good friends. She is fine. Everything is fine. That is the problem. Everything is fine and nothing ever changes. And Rosa is thirty-one and has never been anywhere alone. Not even to Manchester.

On Thursday, Rosa tells Paula about the ticket. 'Manchester? On your own?' 'Yes.' Paula chews her sandwich. 'Good,' she says finally. 'Good?' 'You have been in this town for thirty-one years. It is good to go somewhere. Even if it is just Manchester.' Rosa is not sure if that is a compliment.

On Friday night, Rosa does not sleep well. She thinks: Why am I doing this? I have no plan. I

A Ticket for Tomorrow



After a long shift, Rosa buys a ticket to Manchester.

know nobody there. I have a hotel room - that is all. She thinks about cancelling. She picks up her phone twice. At three in the morning, she puts the phone down. 'I bought the ticket. I will go.' She closes her eyes. She does not cancel.

On Saturday at eight fifteen, Rosa is on the train. She has a small bag and a book she will probably not read. The train moves north. The fields are green and wet. Rosa looks out of the window. She thinks about nothing. This is unusual for her - she always thinks about patients, schedules, her to-do list. But now, just green fields and the sound of the wheels. She feels - strangely - good.

Manchester is loud. Trams, buses, taxis, and people everywhere. Rosa walks to the hotel. She gets lost once - she goes right instead of left. She finds the right street. She finds the hotel. The room is small and clean - a view of a brick building. She sits on the bed. She smiles. She is in Manchester.

Rosa walks to the Northern Quarter. There is a market - small stalls with food, clothes, plants, old things. Rosa walks slowly. She buys a coffee from a stall and sits on a low wall watching people. She

A Ticket for Tomorrow



Rosa travels alone by train, nervous but hopeful.

does not know anyone. Nobody knows her. She is completely free. This is a strange feeling. A good strange. She finishes her coffee and looks at the books on the next stall.

In the evening, Rosa goes to a small restaurant near the hotel. She has a table for one. The waiter does not make it awkward. She orders fish and a glass of wine. Then a man at the next table speaks to her. 'Is the food good here? I am looking for recommendations.' Rosa looks up. The man is about thirty-five. He has kind eyes. 'Very good,' she says. 'The fish especially.' 'Thank you. I am Marcus.' 'Rosa.'

Marcus is a chef from Manchester. He worked in London for ten years. 'I came back last month. I am opening a restaurant here.' 'Here in Manchester?' 'Yes. Small place. Not open yet.' He looks at Rosa's fish. 'That looks good.' 'It is,' Rosa says. She is surprised by how easy this is - talking to a stranger. 'You are not from here.' 'No. I am here for one night.' Marcus smiles. 'Tell me anyway.'

They talk through dinner. Rosa tells Marcus about nursing - the long shifts, the small town. Marcus tells her about London. 'I was successful.'

Good restaurant. Good reviews. But I was not - present.' 'Present?' Rosa asks. 'Here. In my own life. I was always working. But I was not happy.' He shrugs. 'Manchester is home. So I came back.' Rosa thinks about the word: present.

After dinner they walk along the canal. It is cold. The city lights are in the water. They walk slowly. 'Why did you come here alone?' Marcus asks. Rosa thinks. 'I wanted to see if I could,' she says. 'And?' 'I think I can,' Rosa says. Marcus smiles. 'Good answer.' They walk a little more. Then they say goodnight at the corner. Rosa walks back to the hotel. She does not look at her phone.

On Sunday morning, Rosa wakes up at seven thirty. She has breakfast - eggs, toast, orange juice. She looks out at the brick building. She thinks about yesterday: the market, the fish, Marcus, the word present. She has four hours before her train. She puts on her coat and goes out. She walks with no plan.

Rosa finds herself outside an art gallery. It is free. She goes in. She walks slowly through the rooms. There is one photograph she stops at. It shows a woman standing in a field. Her back is to the camera. She is looking at the horizon. The

A Ticket for Tomorrow



In Manchester, Rosa meets Marcus at a market.

title: Waiting or Choosing? Rosa looks at it for a long time. She takes a photograph of it on her phone.

At twelve, Rosa goes to a café near the station. She orders tea and opens her notebook. She writes: "Things I did this weekend that I have never done before: Came to a city alone. Got lost and found it again. Talked to a stranger at dinner. Walked with no plan. Stood in front of a photograph for a long time." She reads the list. It is not big. But it is hers.

The train goes south. Rosa sits by the window. She has a message from Paula: 'How was Manchester?' Rosa smiles. She types: 'Good. Very good. I got lost once. I ate fish. I talked to a chef. I am coming back.' Paula replies immediately: 'Coming back to Manchester or coming back HERE?' Rosa laughs. 'Both,' she writes.

Rosa is home by five. The flat is the same - small, comfortable, tidy. She puts her bag down. She makes tea. She looks at the flat. Same walls. Same kitchen. Same window with the same view of the park. But she feels different. Not a big different. Just - a little more present. She makes the art gallery photograph her phone wallpaper.

Waiting or Choosing.

Six weeks later, Rosa has a day off. She opens her laptop and looks at trains. Manchester again? Or somewhere new? She looks at the options: Leeds. Liverpool. York. Edinburgh. She thinks: Edinburgh. She finds a small hotel near the old city. She books one night. She closes the laptop. She does not tell anyone. Not yet. Maybe on Thursday.

Rosa sends Marcus a message: 'Hi Marcus. It is Rosa from Manchester. The nurse. The fish.' She almost does not send it. She reads it five times. She sends it. Marcus replies in twenty minutes. 'Rosa from Manchester. I remember. How are you?' 'Good. I booked Edinburgh for next month.' 'Going alone again?' 'Yes. It is becoming a habit.' Marcus sends a laughing face. Then: 'I like that.'

In March, Marcus sends Rosa a message: 'The restaurant opens on the 12th. It is called Present. Would you come?' Rosa is working on the 12th. She asks Paula to swap shifts. Paula reads the message over Rosa's shoulder. She does not ask questions. She just says: 'Yes. Go.' Rosa books the train. She messages Marcus: 'I will be there.'

The restaurant is small. Ten tables. Stone walls. Candles. Rosa arrives at seven thirty. Marcus comes out of the kitchen when he sees her. They shake hands - then he laughs and they hug instead. The food is extraordinary. After dinner, Marcus sits with her. Rosa says: 'Why did you call it Present?' Marcus looks at her. 'Because of something someone said to me once,' he says. Rosa nods. She knows the word. She is here. In this small restaurant. She is completely present.

Story Vocabulary

The words below are collected from the story. They are given together so the reading pages stay like a real story book.

1. shift	vardiya	2. uniform	üniforma
3. return ticket	gidiş-dönüş bileti	4. does not tell anyone	kimseye söylemez
5. grew up	büyüdü	6. comfortable	rahat
7. tidy	düzenli	8. the problem	sorun
9. even	bile	10. on your own	kendi başına
11. cafeteria	kafeterya	12. chews	çiğner
13. finally	sonunda	14. compliment	iltifat
15. cancelling	iptal etmek	16. picks up her phone	telefonunu alır
17. twice	iki kez	18. puts down	bırakır
19. fields	tarlalar	20. wet	ıslak
21. unusual	alışılmadık	22. patients	hastalar
23. wheels	tekerlekler	24. trams	tramvaylar
25. gets lost	kaybolur	26. instead of	yerine
27. brick building	tuğla bina	28. view	manzara
29. stalls	tezgâhlar	30. low wall	alçak duvar
31. completely free	tamamen özgür	32. strange feeling	tuhaf his
33. table for one	tek kişilik masa	34. awkward	garip, rahatsız edici
35. recommendations	tavsiyeler	36. especially	özellikle
37. originally	aslen	38. plate	tabak

39. surprised by	... karşısında şaşırmış	40. stranger	yabancı
41. tell me anyway	yine de anlat	42. nursing	hemşirelik
43. reviews	değerlendir meler	44. present	an'da, burada
45. own life	kendi hayatı	46. shrugs	omuz silker
47. canal	kanal	48. city lights	şehir ışıkları
49. I wanted to see if I could	yapıp yapam ayacağımı görmek istedim	50. goodnight	iyi geceler
51. wakes up	uyanır	52. orange juice	portakal suyu
53. four hours	dört saat	54. no plan	plansız
55. art gallery	sanat galerisi	56. free	ücretsiz
57. back is to the camera	kameraya sırtı dönük	58. horizon	ufuk
59. Waiting or Choosing?	Beklemek mi Seçmek mi?	60. notebook	defter
61. list	liste	62. got lost	kayboldum
63. stood in front of	önünde durdum	64. hers	onun (kendisine ait)
65. message	mesaj	66. immediately	hemen
67. coming back	geri dönüyor	68. both	ikisi de
69. laughs	güler	70. the same	aynı
71. wallpaper	ekran duvar kağıdı	72. a little more present	biraz daha burada
73. day off	izin günü	74. options	seçenekler

75. books	rezervasyon yapar	76. not yet	henüz değil
77. sends	gönderir	78. almost	neredeyse
79. booked	rezervasyon yaptı	80. becoming a habit	alışkanlık haline geliyor
81. opens	açılıyor	82. would you come	gelir misin
83. swap shifts	vardiyaları değiştirmek	84. I will be there	orada olacağım
85. stone walls	taş duvarlar	86. candles	mumlar
87. extraordinary	olağanüstü	88. hug	sarılmak
89. completely present	tamamen burada, an'da		

After-Reading Activities

1. Vocabulary Practice - Match the Words

Match each word with the correct meaning.

1. shift

A. vardiyayı değiştir

2. swap shifts

B. vardiya

3. awkward

C. tamamen özgür

4. completely free

D. garip, rahatsız edici

5. present

E. burada, an'da

6. extraordinary

F. olağanüstü

7. horizon

G. ufuk

8. candles

H. mumlar

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word from the box and write it in the blank.

ticket - alone - present - lost - habit - free

1. Rosa buys a _____ to Manchester on a Tuesday evening.

2. She goes to Manchester _____ - she does not take anyone.

3. She gets _____ once in Manchester, but finds the hotel.

4. Marcus says he was not _____ in his own life in

London.

5. Going to new cities alone is becoming a _____ for Rosa.

6. In Manchester, Rosa feels completely _____ because nobody knows her.

3. Comprehension Questions

True or False? Write T or F.

1. Rosa has been to Manchester many times before. ____

2. Paula tells Rosa not to go. ____

3. Marcus is a nurse. ____

4. Rosa finds an art gallery on Sunday morning. ____

5. Rosa books Edinburgh six weeks after Manchester. ____

6. Marcus names his restaurant "Present." ____

Short Answer Questions

7. Why does Rosa buy a ticket to Manchester?

8. What does Rosa tell herself on Friday night when she wants to cancel?

9. What word does Marcus use that stays with Rosa?

10. What is the title of the photograph Rosa sees in the art gallery?

11. What does Rosa write in her notebook before the train home?

12. Where does Rosa decide to go six weeks later?

13. Why does Rosa ask Paula to swap shifts?

14. Why does Marcus call his restaurant "Present"?

15. How does Rosa feel at the end of the story?

Answer Key

(Alıştırmaları yaptıktan sonra bakınız.)

Match: 1-B 2-A 3-D 4-C 5-E 6-F 7-G 8-H

Fill in the Blanks: 1. ticket 2. alone 3. lost 4. present 5. habit 6. free

True / False: 1. F 2. F 3. F 4. T 5. T 6. T

7. She wants something to change. She has never been anywhere alone.

8. She tells herself: "I bought the ticket. I will go."

9. "Present" - being present in your own life.

10. "Waiting or Choosing?"

11. A list of things she did for the first time.

12. Edinburgh.

13. Marcus's restaurant is opening and she wants to go.

14. Because of something Rosa said to him about being present.

15. She is completely present - exactly where she chose to be.